chief minister Bhagwant Mann by his side in most of these rallies.

Addressing such gatherings, the AAP supremo often repeats that his interim bail was a divine intervention. Delhi minister Saurabh Bharadwaj is more direct. "The BJP's biggest blunder was to get Kejriwal arrested right after the election was announced. Because of his arrest, there is only one narrative playing out since March 21, and that is Arvind Kejriwal," he says. "First it was about his arrest, then it was about him challenging his arrest in courts, and then it was about his fight for access to insulin inside the jail...."

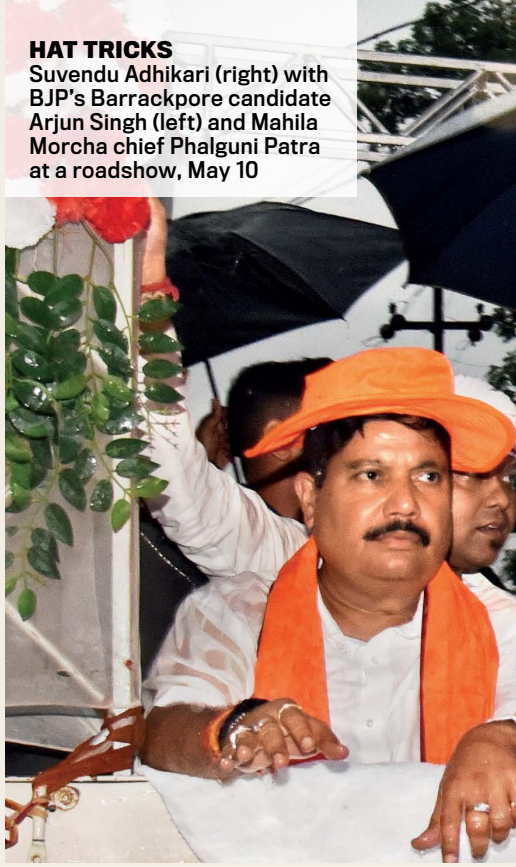
But Virendra Sachdeva, the Delhi BJP chief, believes that no such narrative is at play on the ground. "Kejriwal was arrested through a legal process and then given interim bail by the court. Let them say it's all the BJP's doing. What else can they say?" he says, while claiming there are only two electoral issues in Delhi—"Kejriwal's corruption and 10 years of development carried out by Prime Minister Narendra Modi".

KEJRIWAL'S INTERIM BAIL IS FOR 21 DAYS, UNTIL JUNE 1. THE SUPREME COURT HAS ALLOWED HIM THIS RELIEF ONLY TO CAMPAIGN. AND HE IS LEAVING NO STONE UNTURNED TO MILK THIS OPPORTUNITY

The AAP is up against perhaps the strongest and the most organised election-winning machinery India has seen in decades. But for the first time in 10 years, Kejriwal seems to have seized the conversations in a Lok Sabha election. So much so that the BJP leadership is even questioning his bail. Talking to a news agency, Union home minister Amit Shah termed it as "not a routine judgment", adding that "a lot of people in this country believe that a special treatment has been given". The AAP, in return, charged Shah with "openly challenging the wisdom of the Supreme Court", calling it the BJP's attempt to "bulldoze the Constitution and establish a dictatorship".

So, why is the BJP bothered? Kejriwal has the potential to trouble the BJP with counter questions and upset or reset narratives at the local level, feels Prof. Rajarshi Dasgupta of the Centre for Political Studies, Jawaharlal Nehru University, Delhi. The impact could be seen even in other Hindi belt states that "no longer look leaning towards the BJP as they did in 2019". "Kejriwal and AAP's importance lies in the claim to deliver an alternative model of social welfarist governance," Dasgupta says. "The existence of such alternatives hurt the prospects of the central government which has made good of the fact that there is supposedly no alternative to Modi."

An alternative is exactly what Kejriwal is professing to be. "On June 4, the INDIA bloc's government will come to power. AAP will be a part of it," he said at his first public address, purportedly a press conference, before an overcrowded Rouse Avenue party office soon after coming out on bail. "I will tour the entire country and fight to save my nation against dictatorship. *Mere khoon ka ek ek qatra mere desh ke naam qurbaan hai* (I'll sacrifice every single drop of my blood for my nation)." The delivery is perfect, the timing is immaculate. But will it be good enough? The Delhi voter will answer that only at the hustings. ■



HAT TRICKS
Suvendu Adhikari (right) with BJP's Barrackpore candidate Arjun Singh (left) and Mahila Morcha chief Phalguni Patra at a roadshow, May 10

That only a strong leader—feared and respected in equal measure—can bridge differences between rivals in his party was evident in a BJP roadshow in the Naihati assembly segment of the Barrackpore Lok Sabha seat in West Bengal on May 10. Sharing space on the lead vehicle was BJP's Barrackpore candidate Arjun Singh and its West Bengal Mahila Morcha chief Phalguni Patra. Patra, a resident of Barrackpore, was an aspirant for the nomination before it went to Singh, who had won the seat for the BJP in 2019 before rejoining the Trinamool Congress in 2022. After he was dropped from the TMC's list of candidates for the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, Singh returned to the saffron camp and was given the ticket. Needless to say, Patra didn't like it. But the glue that prompted both to present a unified front that afternoon was there with them atop the car—leader of the opposition and BJP leader Suvendu Adhikari, who spotted Patra in the crowd and asked her to hop on.

Indeed, the Nandigram MLA has emerged as a unifier of disparate elements in the BJP. Many of the party old guard—several of them fierce critics of Adhikari once—are now backing the man who has been taking the fight to the TMC, pinning them down on a slew of alleged corruption scams plaguing the incumbent party and its leaders. Most BJP leaders have been heeding his call to "get to work" to help BJP candidates win. As if to claim that the secret to defeat